PAKISTAN

This country has gone through a number of critical changes since our report was issued on January 30, 2008.

Previous to that time, former Prime Minister Benazir Bhutto had returned to her country, had entered into what appeared to be inconclusive negotiations with President Musharraf over future governance, and was assassinated on December 26th 2007.

President Musharraf's position as leader of his country had been eroding since March of 2007 when he tried to remove the Chief Justice of his country who had challenged the government over a number of cases which they considered important to their remaining in power.

Subsequently, there were public protests and a crack down on the Red Mosque in Islamabad occupied by extremists. These were handled ineptly. The army has been taking a heavy role in efforts to increase their authority and their independence of the government. Previously exiled Prime Minister, Nawaz Sharif, returned from exile in Saudi Arabia, and was re-exiled in apparent disregard of a court order.

Sharif and the remnants of Bhutto's party, led by her controversial husband Asaf Zardari, contested an election postponed from early February 2008 and Bhutto's Party won with Musharraf left well behind. The two opposition parties made common cause and agreed on a coalition government which has in turn sought to reinstate the deposed Chief Justice in contrast to Musharraf's past efforts to side line him.

Pakistan remains divided with Musharraf, previously the US chosen favorite, in serious if not total decline. The two opposition parties, weakened by the loss of Benazir Bhutto, are not certain to be able to provide the kind of leadership desired to see the struggle against terrorism and Islamic fundamentalism inside Pakistan and in Afghanistan continue and move toward success.

The two countries, Afghanistan and Pakistan, are closely tied together in the struggle against terrorist fundamentalism, the Taliban and al Qa'eda. There is no real resolution of the issue if the two are not closely combined in the solution. Pakistan has shown itself, in the short term at least, weakened in this effort by the shift away from Musharraf and an increasingly independent line taken by the opposition parties who are acutely aware of the dangers but also wish to avoid being seen as US surrogates inside Pakistan.

Despite Pakistan's efforts over the past four and more years, the Taliban and al Qa'eda have not diminished in size and influence inside Afghanistan and by the reckoning of some have actually grown in strength and control. Their new position makes the pursuit of them and the further development of Afghanistan even more difficult. Troubling too have been the reports that the very large sums of US money provided Pakistan for this effort have not seemingly made a serious difference and some reports indicate the possibility of diversion of such funds from programs designed to reinforce Pakistan's ability to fight the insurgency and the fundamentalists.

Other outside commentators had also noted that large scale intervention in Pakistan's tribal areas in the Federally Administered Tribal Areas would themselves be ''disastrous for both Pakistan and US interests and would not provide a lasting solution to the problem.''[K Inderfurth, April 1, 2008, File/The Boston Globe]

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